Alien Boy
By Will Scheffer

ALIEN BOY: Today I am thirteen. I don't want to be thirteen. I have always yearned to be older than my years. Therefore I have been described as a precocious child. I drink coffee. I smoke cigarettes. I use the words: masturbatory, ennui, and existential-liberally in conversation. But today I am thirteen. I am wearing my sailor suit. I come down here often in my sailor suit, to the Howard Johnson's in Bloomfield, New Jersey, and I wait. I wait for a man to come and take me away, away from this childhood that I do not belong in. A blonde man who is muscular and bold, I have seen him on TV. He will teach me how to be athletic and brave. He will give structure and meaning to my life. He will hold me in the dark. Just we two. I wait and wait. But he never seems to come.

INTRODUCTION

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ALIEN BOY: I was supposed to be Bar Mitzvahed today. But I told my mother I wouldn't go. I told her I had decided I didn't want to be Jewish anymore. My mother was distraught.

"You can't just decide you don't want to be Jewish anymore," she said.
I told her again, "I don't want to be Jewish."
"Why don't you want to be Jewish?" she asked me.

"In the street, children throw pennies at me, they call me Jew Bagel, in an age when it is possible for us to choose our own destiny, I have decided I don't want to go through life with the particular disadvantage of being a Jew. I want to be Blonde and Handsome like the men on TV. I want to drive a Volkswagen."

"Over my dead body, you'll drive a Volkswagen. This wouldn't be happening if your father were alive."
"He's not alive," I said, "he's dead!"
My mother took a Valium and locked herself in her bedroom.

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My father was a Jew.He came to America during World War Two. He was-an Alien. He left behind his mother, sister, his first wife, and a son. They died at Auschwitz. I have here their names, as listed by the Red Cross. Rebecca, Betsy, Rachel, and the son, Wolf, who was shoveled into an oven on the day of his thirteenth birthday in 1943. *[He burns the names of his relatives with flash paper.]*

I never got along with my father. He spoke with a heavy foreign accent. He was thin and pale and European, not at all like the men on TV. One day I was walking around the house in my mother's high heels and my father caught me. He slapped me and told me: "I never want you to walk in high heels again. Soon you will be thirteen, you will be Bar Mitzvahed, soon you will be a man."

"I don't want to be a man," I told him.
"You're a man, I wish you were dead."

The next year he died of lung cancer. Now I wear my mother's high heels whenever she's not home. *[He puts on high heels and twirls while humming West Side Story.]*

I turn up the music from West Side Story and I twirl my baton. *[When the lyrics reach: "I feel pretty, and witty, and gay"... The music stops with a screech and horror music fades in.]*

Last night after my mother had cooked me a Swanson's frozen TV dinner, I was reading Everything You Always Wanted to Know About Sex but Were Afraid to Ask by David Rueben, M.D., and I quote:

VOICEOVER: "Male Homosexuality is a condition in which men have a driving emotional and sexual interest in other men. Because of the anatomical and physiological limitations involved, there are some formidable obstacles to overcome. In the process they often transform themselves into part-time women. They don women's clothes, wear makeup, adopt feminine mannerisms, and occasionally even try to rearrange their bodies along feminine lines."

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ALIEN BOY: I don't want to be a homosexual. Until last night I didn't know I was one. I knew I was different, but I didn't think there was a name for it. I knew I liked to wear my mother's slip. I knew I liked to wrestle with my friend Nicky Sabatini, and I knew I didn't mind losing. I knew I liked to rub against the sofa watching Monty Hall on Let's Make a Deal and the cowboys on Bonanza. But then I read this:

VOICEOVER: "Some of the more routine items that find their way into the gastrointestinal systems of homosexuals via the exit are pens, pencils, lipsticks, combs, pop bottles, ladies' electric shavers, and enough other items to stock a small department store."

ALIEN BOY: That night I have a disturbing dream. Outside my window I see strange lights. A spaceship lands and a robot man descends from its steps and comes into my bedroom, He is very blonde and looks like my GI Joe doll and the devastatingly handsome Nazis I have seen in war films. He comes to my bed and takes me on his lap. He looks very cold like metal but when he touches me his skin is hot. He holds me in his hot arms. He says that: "You must tell me that you love me." I look into his blonde eyes. I start to form the words I love you. "I... Love..." I wake up screaming. *[Sound: a horror' movie scream.]*

It's two in the morning. I creep into the kitchen and go for the Yellow Pages. I look under the letter P. I find the names of all psychiatrists in Bloomfield. Both of them. Dr. Kaplan and Dr. Casey. I choose Dr. Casey, because he sounds more attractive. I write him a brief letter:

"Dear Dr. Casey:
I think I am a homosexual. I have no money. I cannot tell my mother. Please help me. I want to be cured."

I find a stamp in my mother's pocketbook. For the rest of the night I dream of my doctor. The one who will save me. The man I've been waiting for.

The next day while carrying my tuba, I mail the letter to my doctor. The boys at school have stopped calling me Jewboy and have begun to call me pussy and faggot. I now dress in work boots and flannel shirts to disguise myself. Anxious weeks pass as daily, I run home after school to check the mailbox. Every night I stay awake until 4, praying to the God I do not

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believe in to save me from my sordid fate. Then one day a letter arrives addressed to me. *[ALIEN BOY clutches the letter to his chest and opens it, his heart pounding.]*

He will see me one week from today in his office. I am filled with excruciating anticipation. The week passes quickly, and on the day of our assignation I run from school to the bus that will take me to my hero. I have dressed in my argyle shirt and socks, corduroy bell-bottoms and platform shoes, tempting derogatory slurs from the boys in gym class, but I don't care, I am reckless with expectation.

I arrive at the address of Dr. Casey's office. I ring the bell and am buzzed into a small waiting room. "I'm here to see Dr. Casey," I say to the secretary with a hint of pride. As she knocks suspiciously on the doctor's door I look around his office. I am disappointed to find other people here. The secretary returns and ushers me into Dr. Casey's office. Suddenly, as I am face to face with the man who knows my secret, I realize why I have felt vaguely disoriented since arriving. Dr. Casey is a black person, like his secretary and the people in the waiting room. I am momentarily unable to process this information, as I have never seen a black doctor on TV. But the look of kindness in his handsome face reassures me. I imagine my small white face pressed against his strong black chest. The secretary leaves and the doctor asks me a few questions. "Why do you think you're a homosexual?"

"Because I like men," I tell him.
"What do you want to do with them?"
"I don't know-just be with them," I offer, searching for the correct answers.

Dr. Casey seems satisfied with my answers and then rises from behind his desk. "I'd like to help you," he says. "But you understand I can't possibly treat you without the permission of your mother." He hands me the phone. "I'm afraid you'll have to call her and tell her where you are."

I dial my mother's phone number at work, unable to look him in the eyes. "Hello Mom?" "I'm at a doctor's office." "No, nothing's wrong." I hand the phone to Dr. Casey. "I think you should come down and pick your son up," he says. "313 Franklin Street." He hangs up the phone. "I'm sorry," he says. I look into Dr. Casey's eyes. [Pause] "I... You... Nigger*!"* *[Sound: a horror*

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movie scream.] [The BOY puts his hands over his ears. A beat.]

My mother collects me at Dr. Casey's office and she tells him: "What he's lacking is a male role model." Dr. Casey agrees and offers to treat me, but my mother nervously replies that, "There is a Dr. Kaplan in town, who I think would be a more appropriate choice for us." We walk briskly to the car. We sit in front of Dr. Casey's office in silence. My mother lights a cigarette. "Why didn't you tell me about this...problem?"

"There is no problem, I feel better already."
"Really, I think it's just a passing phase you're going through."
"Yes, I feel it passing already as we speak."
"What would you like for dinner?"
"Can we go to McDonald's?"
"Yes, I think that's a wonderful idea."

And that's the last we talk about it. Years pass.

I look at myself in the mirror as I prepare to meet my mother in New Jersey. After thirty years I must admit my boyish good looks and full head of hair have not diminished. I look remarkably like my dead father. An irony I am not unaware of.

I take the bus from New York City to my mother's small apartment. We see each other often, my mother and myself. We share an easy intimacy. As easy as either of us is capable. We even talk about my boyfriends.

Tonight my mother's taking me to dinner at McDonald's. Close and within walking distance, it is most convenient now that she doesn't drive anymore. I haven't been to a McDonald's in years, but it's the same as I remember it. It's different; but it hasn't really changed. It's like Cher.

My mother and I eat Big Macs and talk about current events. My mother is ecstatic about the passing of the "Gay Marriage Bill" in Vermont. She looks forward to the day I settle down with someone. She wants me to have the kind of love she had with my father. To not be lonely.

"Are you lonely?" I ask her. "No, no. I have so many friends," she says.
"Why didn't you ever remarry?"
"After your father, there was nobody else for me. You know that."

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"Do you miss him?" she asks.
"Yes," I answer. "I miss him very much."
She delicately chews on a French fry. "I miss him too." She takes a gulp of Diet Sprite. McDonald's seems to be making her nostalgic.

"But I wish I had done a better job, with you.. .after. . .," she says. "You know, I still feel bad about when you went to see that psychiatrist, what was his name?"
"Dr. Casey," I answer.
"I should never have made him call me."
"Oh, Ma," I say, "You're confused. He made ME call YOU. He was a bad psychiatrist. He betrayed my trust."

And then it all comes out:
"No."
"I never told you this, but I opened that letter you got from Dr. Casey, you know saying he would see you. I made him have you call me from his office. I told him I'd sue him if he didn't. I was so desperate to know why you contacted him. I didn't know what else to do."

And suddenly it feels like I am falling. As if the room around me is falling away:
"Darling."
"I'm sorry."
"Please forgive me."
"I love you."
"It's O.K.," I say. I stare at my hot apple pie. "You did the best you could." I start to form the words I love you. "I...love..." Inside myself I hear the roar of wind and the sound of combustion. "I love you, Ma. I forgive you. I love you. Of course, I love you."

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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